StraightScale

The WORDS Sheet

12 copy-paste searches that find your buyers' exact sentences. Start with 6 of them, in one sitting of 20 to 30 minutes.

From StraightScale (@straightscale_). These are the searches we run before we make any content. We collected 567 buyer sentences this way before our first video.

Why this works

If your posts and ads are not booking calls, a common reason is that they sound like marketing. Your buyers have already described their problem in public, in their own words. The hook of the reel that sent you here was one of those: a business owner's sentence from a review, copied as it was written.

One rule for every search: **search with pain words, not product words.** Search "feast or famine", not "business coaching". People write pain words when they complain, and that is where the honest sentences are.

Before you start (2 minutes)

1. Open a blank doc with three columns: **FEAR**, **DESIRE**, **IDENTITY**.
2. Fill in these blanks. They go into the searches below.
   - `[BUYER]` : who pays you, in their words, not yours (example: `new manager` , `agency owner` , `dentist`)
   - `[COMPETITOR]` : a competitor's name (example: `Acme Coaching`)
   - `[COMPETITOR WEBSITE]` : their website as a bare domain (example: `acmecoaching.com` , no https or www)
   - `[PAIN]` : a pain phrase your buyers use (example: `feast or famine`)
   - `[CITY]` : only if you sell locally (example: `London`)
3. No pain phrase yet? Start with these, all from the sentences we collected: `lumpy` , `feast or famine` , `sporadic` , `not predictable` , `black box` , `tried everything` , `zero sales` , `race to the bottom` . They are business-owner pains. If your buyers are not business owners, write 3 phrases they would say to a friend about the problem, and use those.
4. **The first run:** do the search marked **Start here** in each section (6 searches, about 3 minutes each; give it longer if a thread is good). Do the other 6 next time.

The filled examples use our own buyers (agency owners and coaches). Swap in yours.

How to sort what you copy

One question per sentence: is this what they're running from, what they want, or who they say they are?

Column	Rule	A real example (source, date)
FEAR	a pain, past or present: what they lost, wasted, are tired of	"I paid $15,000 for appointment-setting services and, over four-plus months, received zero sales." (Trustpilot, 1 star, 29 Sep 2026)
DESIRE	an outcome they want, or a question they ask	"How are you acquiring stable clientele outside of direct referrals?" (Reddit comment, collected Oct 2026)
IDENTITY	how they describe themselves or their place in the market ("as a...", "I'm the one who...")	"I was in a race to the bottom on pricing, and I knew it." (Substack, 30 Jan 2026)

Tie-break: if a sentence fits two columns, IDENTITY wins over FEAR, and FEAR wins over DESIRE. Label beats pain, pain beats wish.

Three rules:

- **Copy, never polish.** Paste the sentence exactly, typos included. Once it's polished, it sounds like an ad.
- **Write the source and date** next to each one, never the person's name.
- **Skip the vague ones.** "Great service!" tells you nothing. Keep sentences with a number, a time, a thing they tried, or a feeling.

1. Competitors' Google reviews (3 minutes)

Best for local businesses. Selling online with few Google reviews? Skip to section 2 and do Search 3 and 4 both.

Search 1. Start here. In Google Maps, search:

> **[COMPETITOR] [CITY]**

Open the business, click **Reviews**, then **Sort** and choose **Lowest**. Then sort again by **Highest**.

Search 2. In Google, for reviews of a competitor on other sites:

> **"[COMPETITOR]" reviews -site:[COMPETITOR WEBSITE]**

Filled example: `"Acme Coaching" reviews -site:acmecoaching.com` (Acme is a placeholder: use a real competitor)

- **What to copy:** in the 1 to 3 star reviews, the sentence that says what they paid for and never got. In the 5 star reviews, the line that describes their life before.
- **Sort it:** mostly FEAR. "What finally worked" in a 5 star review is DESIRE.

2. Review sites (3 minutes)

Search 3. Start here. In Google:

> **site:trustpilot.com "[PAIN]" [BUYER]**

Filled example: `site:trustpilot.com "zero sales" agency`

Search 4. On a competitor's Trustpilot page, show only the 1 and 2 star reviews (domain only, as in setup):

> **https://www.trustpilot.com/review/[COMPETITOR WEBSITE]?stars=1&stars=2**

For agencies, try Clutch the same way: `site:clutch.co "[PAIN]" [BUYER]`.

- **What to copy:** the sentence where they explain why they bought, and the one where they explain what went wrong. 5 star reviews often open with the problem in one line, like the one the reel opened with: "2 years of posting content, running ads, and praying someone books a call." (Trustpilot, 5 stars, 20 Aug 2025)
- **Sort it:** what went wrong is FEAR. Why they bought: FEAR if it is a pain, DESIRE if it is an outcome. "As a small agency" is IDENTITY.

Your buyers' kind of business is not on Trustpilot? In the Amazon search box, type `[BUYER] [PAIN]`, open the top 3 books on their problem, and read the 2 and 3 star reviews (filled example: `new manager overwhelmed`).

3. Reddit (3 minutes)

Search 5. Start here. In Google:

> **site:reddit.com "[PAIN]" [BUYER]**

Filled example: `site:reddit.com "feast or famine" agency owner`

Search 6. In Google, for threads where your buyers ask for help:

> **site:reddit.com "[BUYER]" ("I'm struggling" OR "how do I" OR "any advice")**

Filled example: `site:reddit.com "agency owner" ("I'm struggling" OR "how do I" OR "any advice")`

Open the thread with the most comments. Read the comments, not just the post.

- **What to copy:** a comment where someone describes their own situation in one or two lines. Example: "I already tried everything in this space, from working with other coaches to Ads, cold DMs... I guess that's it." (r/lifecoaching, 14 Sep 2026)
- **Sort it:** the situation is FEAR, the question is DESIRE, "I'm a solo..." is IDENTITY.

4. Newsletter and Substack comments (3 minutes)

Google finds the posts, not the comments. Open the post and read the comments on the page.

Search 7. Start here. In Google:

> **site:substack.com "[PAIN]" [BUYER]**

Filled example: `site:substack.com "race to the bottom" consultant`

Search 8. In Google, for posts where people like your buyers tell their own story:

> **site:substack.com "[BUYER]" ("worst month" OR "almost quit" OR "I was wrong")**

Filled example: `site:substack.com "agency owner" ("worst month" OR "almost quit" OR "I was wrong")`

- **What to copy:** the author's one-line confession, and comments that start with "This is me" or "Same".
- **Sort it:** use the tie-break. A confession about who they were ("I was the...") is IDENTITY; about what happened, FEAR.

No comments under the posts you find? Many newsletters live on their own domains: search Google for `"[PAIN]" [BUYER] newsletter` instead.

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5. YouTube comments (3 minutes)

Search 9. Start here. In the YouTube search box, your buyer's problem as they would type it:

> **[BUYER] [PAIN]**

Filled example: `agency owner feast or famine`

Search 10. In the YouTube search box, the question your buyer asks:

> **how do I [the result your buyer wants]**

Filled example: `how do I get consistent clients agency`

Pick a video with many comments. Under it, switch the sort to **Newest** for recent sentences, then scroll.

- **What to copy:** comments that start with their situation ("I've been running my agency for 2 years and..."). Skip "great video".
- **Sort it:** their situation is FEAR, a label is IDENTITY, what they want next is DESIRE.

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6. Public Facebook groups (3 minutes)

Search 11. Start here. In the Facebook search bar, type the line below, click the **Groups** filter, then choose **Public groups**. Open one with recent posts and go straight to Search 12 inside it:

> **[BUYER]**

Filled example: `agency owners`

Search 12. Inside the group, use the group's own search box. Private groups you already belong to work too:

> **[PAIN]**

Filled example: `slow month` or `no leads`

- **What to copy:** posts that ask "has anyone else...", and replies that share a number or a story.
- **Sort it:** use the tie-break. "Has anyone else..." with a problem is FEAR; "Looking for advice on..." is DESIRE.
- Never copy names. You are collecting sentences, not people.

When the first run is done

You should have 9 to 15 sentences in three columns. Now:

1. **Circle the sentence that made you wince.** That is your next hook. Use it word for word as the first line of a post or the first words of a video.
2. **Count your columns.** Fewer than 3 sentences in one column means you don't know that part of your buyer yet. An empty FEAR column usually means your content is too polite. An empty IDENTITY column usually means your offer reads like everyone else's.
3. **Do the other 6 searches next time.** The words change as the market changes.

What we do with this

This sheet is step 1 of what we build for clients: **research** before any content. For a client we run the same searches across their buyers, competitors and market, and build the offer, the content and the ads from what we find, in that order.

If your columns came out thin, or full but you don't know what to do with them, reply in this DM with the word **columns** and your niche.

*StraightScale · @straightscale_*